

**SWITZERLAND****Capital city:** Bern**Area:** 15,942 sq miles
(41,290 sq km)**Population:** 7,200,000**Official languages:**
German, French, Italian,
and Romansch**Major religions:** Christian
86%, Muslim 2%, other 12%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Swiss franc**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 79 years**People per doctor:** 286**Televisions:** 525 per 1,000
people**LIECHTENSTEIN****Capital city:** Vaduz**Area:** 62 sq miles
(160 sq km)**Population:** 33,145**Official language:** German**Major religions:** Christian
88%, other 12%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Swiss franc**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 79 years**People per doctor:** 763

SWITZERLAND

SWITZERLAND HAS BEEN a neutral country since 1815, and has stayed out of all the wars that have affected Europe since that time. It is a country of isolated mountain communities in which people speak several different languages. Despite this, Switzerland is remarkably unified in many ways and has pooled its few resources to create a flourishing economy. Its neutrality and political stability have helped make it a major financial center.

MANUFACTURING

Even though it has virtually no raw materials, Switzerland has made itself a major industrial power. The Swiss have a skilled workforce specializing in producing high-value, lightweight products. Since Switzerland is a small country, Swiss companies have had to export goods in order to find large markets. Many businesses now have branches worldwide.



The pharmaceutical industry is important.

Switzerland is famous for making clocks and watches.

**GENEVA**

Many of Switzerland's banks and businesses are based in the beautiful lakeside city of Geneva. This city is also home to many international organizations, attracted here by Switzerland's political stability and its neutral status. These include the Red Cross, the World Health Organization, and the European headquarters of the United Nations.

AGRICULTURE

Farming is not easy in such mountainous terrain, but the fertile valleys are used extensively, and fruit and grape vines are grown on warmer, south-facing slopes. Dairy farming is a traditional way of life here. Cattle, sheep, and goats graze on the upland slopes in the warmer months, and are brought down to the valleys for the winter. Their milk is used to produce a variety of cheeses, such as Emmentaler, or Swiss chesse.

French-speaking Swiss people at a street market in Lausanne

**SWISS LANGUAGES**

Four different languages are spoken in Switzerland, Europe's most multi lingual country. German, French, and Italian are the official languages, but a fourth, Romansch, spoken in remote Alpine villages, has been given the status of a national language.

THE ECONOMY

Financial services are vital to the economy, and investors are drawn here by liberal banking laws and political stability. Intensive agriculture, a thriving small-scale manufacturing industry, and tourism bring in large amounts of revenue. Its varied economy makes this an extremely wealthy state.

LIECHTENSTEIN

NESTLING IN THE RHINE VALLEY between Switzerland and Austria, this tiny German-speaking principality is one of very few small European states to hold on to its independence. It is not totally independent, though, as Liechtenstein's Swiss neighbor provides its currency, as well as its postal and telephone services, and also directs the country's foreign policy.

Liechtenstein produces highly decorative postage stamps that are much sought after by collectors. This one celebrates the anniversary of their prince and princess.



Stamp sales are still an important source of income for the state.

Find out more

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